



THE HISTORY PORTAL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

EDITION 2026.1

HOW DID DECADES OF IMPERIAL RIVALRY AND FEAR CULMINATE IN THIRTY DAYS OF MADNESS?

KS3: Causes of the Great War

Scholar: _____

Class: _____

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

TARGET GRADE: _____

Level	Emerging (1-2)	Emerging+ (3)	Expected (4-5)	Expected+ (6-7) / Greater Depth (8-9)
Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments	
L1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?				
L2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?				
L3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?				
L4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?				
L5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?				
L6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?				
Final Unit Grade:				

L1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

☐ Understand how Otto von Bismarck used 'blood and iron' to unify the German states.
☐ Analyze the geographical impact of the new German Empire on the balance of power in Europe.

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?

Chancellor | Blood and Iron

Active Tasks

Q1. Was the German Empire forged through master diplomacy or ruthless military aggression?

Q2. Explain how Otto von Bismarck used "blood and iron" and diplomatic calculation to forge the German Empire in 1871.

[illegible]

L2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

☐ Identify the penalties forced upon France in 1871.
☐ Explain how the Ems Telegram sparked the Franco-Prussian War.
☐ Evaluate the long-term impact on European relations.

Chronological Domino Flowchart

Score: / 5

*Task: The historical events below are out of order. Read them carefully, then use your pen to **draw arrows connecting the boxes** in the correct chronological and causal order (Event A → Event B → Event C...).*

1897

Imperial Rivalries

The Place in the Sun speech

1871

The Unification of Germany

The Franco-Prussian War

1906

The Naval Arms Race

The Launch of HMS Dreadnought

1907

Encirclement & Alliances

The Triple Entente System

June 1914

The Spark in Sarajevo

The Assassination of the Archduke

1. Looking at this long-term timeline, which factor do you think was the most dangerous necessary cause of the war?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Chancellor | Blood and Iron | Revanche | Annexation | Indemnity | Two-Front War | North German Confederation | Reinsurance Treaty

Active Tasks

Q1. Did the annexation of Alsace-Lorraine protect Germany or make a future European war inevitable?

Q2. Explain why the Franco-Prussian War created a lasting legacy of hatred between France and Germany.

L3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the main European colonial powers and their territories.
- ☐ Explain how Kaiser Wilhelm II's 'Place in the Sun' policy threatened Britain.
- ☐ Evaluate the impact of the Moroccan Crises on the Entente Cordiale.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. Who was the first Emperor of the newly unified Germany in 1871?

2. Which brilliant Chancellor united the German states?

3. Which country was humiliatingly defeated in the Franco-Prussian War?

4. What strategic border territory did Germany take in 1871?

5. What is the French word for their desire for revenge?

6. Explain how Bismarck used the Ems Telegram to trap France into a war.

7. Detail the two military advantages the Prussian army possessed.

8. Why was the location of the German Empire's proclamation so humiliating for France?

9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?

10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Imperialism Scramble for Africa Weltpolitik Place in the Sun Entente Cordiale Algeciras Conference Agadir Crisis Gunboat Diplomacy Berlin Conference Congo Free State	
Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society

Active Tasks

Q1. To what extent did the Scramble for Africa and the Moroccan Crises make war in Europe more likely?

Q2. Explain how Kaiser Wilhelm II's policy of Weltpolitik and the Moroccan Crises drove Britain and France into a united diplomatic alliance against Germany.

L4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the significance of the HMS Dreadnought.
- ☐ Explain the concept of the Two-Power Standard and Risk Theory.
- ☐ Analyze how naval competition fed mutual suspicion.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

2. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

3. Why was the Franco-Russian Alliance a strategic disaster for Germany?

4. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

5. Describe the impact of Britain abandoning its policy of 'Splendid Isolation'.

6. Evaluate the role of Wilhelm II's personality in destabilizing Europe.

7. Who dismissed Otto von Bismarck in 1890?

8. What strategic territory did Germany take from France in 1871?

9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?

10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Vocabulary Check

***Spot the Deliberate Error:** Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:*

Naval Supremacy | Two-Power Standard | Arms Race | Dreadnought | German Navy Laws | Navy League | Grand Fleet | High Seas Fleet | Kiel Canal | Scapa Flow

Challenge: Write ONE statement containing a deliberate historical misconception using **Naval Supremacy** or **Two-Power Standard**. Swap with a partner to identify and correct the error:

Active Tasks

Q1. Why did the building of Dreadnought battleships destroy Anglo-German relations?

Q2. Explain why the Anglo-German naval arms race destroyed diplomatic trust between Great Britain and Germany between 1898 and 1914.

L5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the members of the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente.
- ☐ Explain why countries felt the need to form secret defensive treaties.
- ☐ Evaluate how the alliance system could drag all of Europe into a regional conflict.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

2. What was the 'Two-Power Standard'?

3. Why did Germany feel it needed a massive high seas fleet?

4. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

5. What was the popular British slogan chanted by the public in 1909?

6. Why did Britain feel their survival depended on massive naval supremacy?

7. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

8. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

9. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

10. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?

**Triple Alliance | Triple Entente | Encirclement | Blank Cheque | Schlieffen Plan | Mobilisation |
Armed Camps | Preventative War | Reinsurance Treaty**

Active Tasks

Q1. Did the alliance system preserve the peace of Europe or make a continental war inevitable?

Q2. Explain how the division of Europe into the Triple Alliance and Triple Entente transformed minor regional disputes into a continental crisis.

L6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the events of 28 June 1914.
- ☐ Explain how the assassination triggered the alliance system.
- ☐ Analyze whether the resulting war was inevitable or accidental.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. Which three countries made up the Triple Entente?

2. Which three countries made up the Triple Alliance?

3. Explain the theoretical logic of how the alliance system was supposed to keep peace.

4. Why did the alliance system actually increase paranoia instead of security?

5. What military plan did Germany create to avoid a long two-front war?

6. Which neutral country did the Schlieffen Plan require invading?

7. What feeling of being surrounded by enemies haunted German planners?

8. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

9. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

10. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

Vocabulary Check

***The Golden Sentence:** Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):*

Assassination | Black Hand | Pan-Slavism | Annexation | Ultimatum | July Crisis | Mobilisation
| Schlieffen Plan | Treaty of London (1839) | Willy-Nicky Telegrams

Active Tasks

Q1. Was the outbreak of war in August 1914 caused by individual accidents in Sarajevo or deep structural forces?

Q2. Explain why the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo led directly to the outbreak of the First World War in August 1914.

End of Unit Reflection & Pupil Voice

Unit: Causes of the Great War (1870–1914)

Instructions: Now that you have completed your final assessment, take 10 minutes to reflect on your learning across this entire unit. Be honest—this is your chance to use your **Pupil Voice** to help your teacher plan future lessons.

1. What Went Well (WWW)

What topic or skill did you find most engaging or easiest to understand in this unit?

2. Even Better If (EBI)

What did you find most challenging? Are there any concepts you are still confused about?

3. Effort & Target Setting

Circle your effort level for this unit: **1 (Low)** **2** **3** **4** **5 (Excellent)**

What is one specific target you want to set for yourself in the next unit?

Teacher Feedback & Coaching

(To be completed during live marking / feedback lessons)